

On Hittite Bookcraft

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25 VII 2026

1§. First of all, this text is not addressed to Hittitologists, Assyriologists, or philologists, but rather to general linguists who may need some explanation of how cuneiform literature is organised and which genres are commonly associated with it.

The term *Hittite literature* should be understood as an umbrella term. Like other *Cuneiform literatures*, it is usually defined broadly and includes most, or at least a large part, of the cuneiform textual corpus, while normally excluding administrative and lexical texts.

For example, within Sumerology there is still debate as to whether magical texts, letters, laws, and trial records should be regarded as part of a given cuneiform literary tradition; see, for instance, [Black et al. 2004], Röllig's survey of Mesopotamian literature [Röllig 1987–1990], and the *Electronic Text Corpus of Sumerian Literature* [ETCSL]. A similar problem arises in the case of Hittite literature.

In my narrative, I would like to use the concept of *the Hittite literature* in the broadest possible sense, for the same purpose expressions like *literacy practice* or *literary tradition* are often used, so that it corresponds as best as possible to the theme of my original corpus research - to take the largest and most diverse array of Hittite texts and samples of the Hittite language in order to obtain as interesting and complex copies as possible.

I would also like to discuss in advance two important things for further explanation:

1. This work does not carry anything new in terms of structural considerations, or revision of concepts, boundaries of definitions, the role of texts, etc., because it carries primarily a review and demonstrational goal.
2. This work relies entirely and entirely on the more authoritative works of predecessors and is, in many respects, a compilation of their ideas.
3. German.

2§. My principal sources are the classical Hittitological surveys of von Schuler [von Schuler 1987–1990] and Haas [Haas 2006]. The structure of my explanation

is based primarily on the former, while additional genres and examples have been drawn from the latter. Further broad treatments used for comparison include Röllig's anthology of Ancient Near Eastern literatures [Röllig 1978] and Ivanov's surveys of Anatolian, Hittite, and Hurrian literature [Ivanov 1977, Ivanov 1983].

I tried to cover all kinds of genres as much as possible, combining the views and positions of different authors. Probably, this "Frankenstein" is the usefulness or uniqueness of this paper

Today, Hittitologists use the **CTH** (*Catalogue des textes hittites*) to systematise Hittite texts; its current online presentation and extensions are available through the Hethitologie-Portal Mainz (**HPM**) [HPM]. The CTH classification system is as follows:

- I. Historical texts (*Historische Texte*, CTH 1–220)
- II. Administrative and technical texts (*Administrative und fachliche Texte*, CTH 221–290)
- III. Legal texts (*Rechtstexte*, CTH 291–298)
- IV. Scholarly texts (*Gelehrte Texte*, CTH 299–320)
- V. Mythology (*Mythologie*, CTH 321–370)
- VI. Hymns and prayers (*Hymnen und Gebete*, CTH 371–389)
- VII. Rituals (*Rituale*, CTH 390–500)
- VIII. Cult inventories (*Kultinventare*, CTH 501–530)
- IX. Divination (*Divination*, CTH 531–590)
- X. Festival rituals and cults (*Festrituale und Kulte*, CTH 591–724)
- XI. Texts in other languages (*Texte in anderen Sprachen*, CTH 725–791)
- XII. Sumerian–Akkadian literature (*Sumerisch-akkadische Literatur*, CTH 792–819)
- XIII. Miscellanea (*Varia*, CTH 820ff.)

3§. The Hittite literature was neither *naïve* nor *merely derivative*, although rooted in Mesopotamian scribal traditions, it creatively adapted, varied, and recombined Mesopotamian-scribal-school-inherited forms.

A good example for comparison is the relationship between the Ancient Greek and Latin literary traditions, at the very beginning of the latter, when early Roman writers such as Andronicus, Nevius, Plautus or Terentius were inspired by and copied the works of their Greek predecessors. A similar fate did not bypass the Mesopotamian (Sumerian- and Akkadian- speaking traditions) when interacting with the Hittite scribes.

Mesopotamian models underlay letters, laws, omens, royal inscriptions, and epics, while Hittite authors developed distinctive genres of royal inscription youthful deeds, deeds of manhood, and annals, as well as legal forms such as edicts, treaties, instructions, court records, and indictments, and historicizing and forensic prayers continuing the Mesopotamian tradition of lamentation prayers. Complex works could combine smaller forms or transcend conventional genre boundaries. Their literary techniques included sophisticated composition and compilation, shifts of register, stylistically varied prose, rhetoric, colloquial speech, and bound language in *mythological-epic* poetry, with occasional verse embedded in prose. Eleanor Radner's (ed.) and Eleanor Robson's (ed.) books *The Oxford Handbook of Cuneiform Culture* and *Ancient Knowledge Networks* and fresh Eduardo A. Escobar's (ed.) et. al. *Scribal Worlds* provide awesome explanations of those phenomena.

4§. Hittite **historiography** survives in relatively few but formally diverse texts. Its earlier forms include royal inscriptions (*Königsinschriften*), annalistic campaign narratives (*annalistische Feldzugsberichte*), conquest and raiding reports (*Eroberungs- und Raubzugsberichte*), individual campaign reports (*Einzelberichte über Ereignisse während der Feldzüge*), historical-legal accounts (*historisch-juristische Geschichtsdarstellungen*), traditional literature (*Traditionsliteratur*), legendary-historical narratives (*legendäre historische Erzählungen*), anecdotal historiography (*anekdotische Geschichtsschreibung*), and chronicles or chronicle-like historiography (*Chroniken bzw. chronikartige Geschichtsschreibung*).

Thematic historiographical genres comprise youthful deeds (*Jugendtaten*), accounts of deeds of manhood (*Mannestaten*), war and siege reports (*Kriegs- und Belagerungsberichte*), building inscriptions (*Bauinschriften*), and, more marginally, votive or dedicatory inscriptions (*Weiheinschriften*).

Other hybrid forms include the political testament (*politisches Testament*), the collection of exempla or palace chronicle (*Exempelsammlung oder Palastchronik*), and historiographical sections embedded in edicts and treaties (*Erlasse und Staatsverträge*).

In the New Hittite Kingdom, these traditions developed into annals (*Annalistik*), accounts of royal deeds (*Mannestaten bzw. Rechenschaftsberichte*), royal apology and autobiography (*Apologie und Autobiographie*), memoranda (*Memoranden*), and historical introductions to treaties (*historische Einleitungen der Staatsverträge*), often combining chronological narration with dynastic legitimation, political argument, and moral exemplarity [von Schuler 1987–1990, Haas 2006, HPM].

5§. **Mythological, poetic, and narrative** literature (*Mythos, Dichtung und erzählende Literatur*) resists rigid generic classification, since works conventionally described as myths (*Mythen*), epics (*Epen*), tales (*Erzählungen*), or songs (*Lieder or Gesänge*) frequently overlap, and many mythological narratives remained embedded in ritual contexts.

Its principal corpora comprise Anatolian myths (*anatolische or zentralanatolische*

Mythen), particularly disappearance-and-return myths (*Mythen vom Verschwinden und Wiederkehren einer Gottheit*) and dragon-combat myths (*Drachenkampfmythen*), the Hurro-Hittite Kumarbi myths (*Kumarbi-Mythen*) and other mytho-poetic compositions (*mytho-poetische Dichtungen*), tales of Hurrian or other foreign origin (*Erzählungen hurritischen oder anderen Ursprungs*), Syrian-Canaanite myths (*syrisch-hethitische mytho-poetische Dichtungen* or *kanaanäische Mythen*), and Mesopotamian epics and legendary narratives (*mesopotamische Epen und legendäre Erzählungen*), transmitted through translation and adaptation.

More specific forms include heroic tales and heroic deeds (*Heldenerzählungen und Heldentaten*), fairy tales (*Märchen*), prose poems (*Prosa-Dichtungen*), didactic narrative folk literature (*didaktische und erzählende Volksliteratur*), parables (*Parabeln*), dream narratives (*Traumerzählungen*), curse compositions (*Fluchdichtungen*), incantatory narratives (*Beschwörungserzählungen*), mythologems (*Mythologeme*), historioli (*Historiolae*), and song poetry (*Lieddichtungen und Gesänge*), including soldiers' songs (*Soldatenlieder*), love songs (*Liebeslieder*), and cult songs (*Kultlieder*).

Individual compositions may therefore combine mythic, epic, ritual, didactic, and lyrical elements rather than conforming to a single stable genre [Haas 2006, Ivanov 1977, Ivanov 1983, HPM].

6§. Prayers and ritual literature (*Gebetsliteratur*) constitutes a flexible, predominantly royal corpus transmitted in Hittite, Akkadian, and Hurrian.

Its principal forms include royal and individual prayers (*Königs- und Individualgebete*), justification prayers (*Rechtfertigungsgebete*), petitionary prayers (*Bittgebete*), intercessory prayers (*Fürbittgebete*), accusation and forensic prayers (*Anklagegebete und forensische Gebete*), historicizing prayers (*historisierende Gebete*), plague prayers (*Pest- oder Epidemie-Gebete*), prayers for healing or recovery (*Gebete um Heilung oder Genesung*), and prayers addressed to the divine assembly (*Gebete an die Götterversammlung*).

Some texts adopt the epistolary form of god-letters (*Gottesbriefe*) or petitionary letters to a deity (*Gottesbittbriefe*), while others combine prayer with a conditional vow (*Gelübde*).

Their usual structure comprises a hymnic proem (*hymnisches Proömium*) or ritual invocation (*Anrufung*), followed by an arkuwar justification or defence speech (*Rechtfertigungs- oder Verteidigungsrede*), confession of guilt, petition, intercession, and promises of offerings or foundations. Closely related forms include hymns (*Hymnen*) and vocations (*Vokationen*), the latter encompassing both the summoning of a deity to a cultic occasion and the evocation of deities from hostile territory. Hittite prayers may also incorporate historiographical narration, legal argumentation, ritual instructions, and divinatory material, making them argumentative, persuasive, and performative compositions rather than texts of purely private devotion.

7§. Hittite ritual and incantation literature (*Ritual- und Beschwörungsliteratur*) *per se* constitutes a large performative and prescriptive corpus intended to remove impurity, illness, divine anger, sorcery, social conflict, or other forms of disorder. Its principal forms include purification rituals (*Reinigungsrituale*), healing rituals (*Heilungsrituale*), birth rituals (*Geburtsrituale*), substitution rituals (*Ersatzrituale*), protective rituals (*Schutzrituale*), anti-witchcraft rituals (*Rituale gegen Behexung*), plague rituals (*Seuchenrituale*), military rituals (*Militärrituale*), building and foundation rituals (*Bau- und Grundsteinlegungsrituale*), and evocation rituals (*Evokationsrituale*), through which absent or alienated deities were summoned. These compositions characteristically combine procedural instructions with spoken incantations (*Beschwörungen*), invocations, analogical actions, symbolic transfers, offerings, and occasionally embedded mythologems (*Mythologeme*) or *historiolae* (*Historiolae*).

Very important to note, that their recitations may be Hittite, Luwian, Palaic, Hattic, Hurrian, or Akkadian, reflecting the multilingual and regionally diverse traditions incorporated into Hittite ritual practice. Unlike festival texts, incantation rituals normally address a particular crisis or individual occasion rather than a regularly recurring cultic celebration [von Schuler 1987–1990, Haas 2006, HPM].

8§. Wisdom literature (*Weisheitsliteratur*) is not securely attested as an autonomous native genre. Its clearest separately transmitted witnesses are Akkadian–Hittite scholastic wisdom texts (*akkadisch-hethitische schulische Weisheitstexte*: CTH 316) and Akkadian wisdom texts (*akkadische Weisheitstexte*: CTH 814), which primarily reflect Mesopotamian scribal transmission. Moralizing maxims or wisdoms (*moralisierende Sentenzen*), admonitions (*Ermahnungen*), proverbs (*Proverbien* or *Sprichwörter*), and proverbial expressions (*Redensarten*) are dispersed through edicts (*Erlasse*), state treaties (*Staatsverträge*), instructions (*Instruktionen*), rituals, and historiographical compositions rather than preserved in a native Hittite collection of wisdom sayings (*hethitische Spruchsammlung*).

The most substantial wisdom material occurs in the Hurro-Hittite moralizing parables (*moralisierende Parabeln*) embedded in the Song of Release: explicitly designated “wisdom” - Hurrian *maḫi* and Hittite *ḫattātar*, they combine a fable-like exemplary narrative (*Fabel* oder *Exempelerzählung*), its application to human conduct, and an explicit moral lesson (*moralische Nutzenanwendung*). Closely related or wisdom-adjacent forms include moral teachings (*moralische Lehren*), advice to a king (*Ratschläge für einen König*), and instructions for proper conduct (*Verhaltensanweisungen*).

Hittite wisdom discourse is therefore best understood as a dispersed, *translated*, or embedded tradition rather than a clearly bounded corpus comparable to Mesopotamian collections of wisdom sayings [von Schuler 1987–1990, Haas 2006, HPM].

9§. Festival and liturgical literature (*Fest- und Kultliteratur*) is represented above all by festival rituals (*Festrituale* or *Festbeschreibungen*), the largest text group in the archives of Ḫattuša. These texts provide concise, specialized prescriptions for the correct performance of the cult on calendrical or seasonal occasions, including

monthly festivals (*Monatsfeste*), spring festivals (*Frühlingsfeste*), autumn festivals (*Herbstfeste*), winter festivals (*Winterfeste*), New Year festivals (*Neujahrsfeste*), and major state celebrations such as the AN.DAḪ.ŠUM festival (AN.DAḪ.ŠUM-Fest).

Their principal documentary forms are overview tablets (*Übersichtstafeln*), which summarize multi-day celebrations, and day tablets (*Tagestafeln*), which prescribe the rites performed on particular days or at particular locations. The texts regulate processions, sacrifices, libations, cult meals, divine journeys, enthronements, music, dance, and ritual recitations, while hymns, songs, myths, and speeches may be embedded within the ceremonial sequence. Closely related materials include cult inventories (*Kultinventare*), ration lists, tablets containing festival recitations, royal cultic decrees, and oracle reports concerning the correct performance of festivals. They are therefore best understood as administrative-performative scripts rather than autonomous literary narratives [Haas 2006, HPM].

10§. **Oath and blessing literature** (*Eid- und Segensliteratur*) comprises performative texts that establish political, military, administrative, or religious obligations through divine sanction. Its clearest independent forms are military oaths (*militärische Eide*), official or loyalty oaths (*Amts- oder Treueide*), such as the Oath of Ašḫapala (*Eid des Ašḫapala*), and oath rituals (*Vereidigungsrituale*), comparable oath clauses also form essential components of state treaties (*Staatsverträge*) and instructions. These compositions invoke divine witnesses and frequently employ conditional self-curses (*Selbstverfluchungen*), ritual analogies, and symbolic acts that dramatize the consequences of disloyalty. Blessings (*Segenssprüche*) promise longevity, fertility, dynastic continuity, military success, and prosperity to the king or the community, but survive much less frequently as independent texts, the Blessing for the Labarna-king (*Segen für den Labarna-König*, CTH 820) is the principal separately catalogued example. Blessing and curse should therefore often be treated not as fully independent genres but as complementary performative components of oaths, treaties, royal ceremonies, and ritual texts [Haas 2006, HPM].

11§. **Epistolary literature** (*Briefliteratur*) constitutes a broad documentary corpus whose principal forms include Egyptian–Hittite, also known as Amarna correspondence (*ägyptisch-hethitische Korrespondenz*), royal letters (*Königsbriefe*), diplomatic correspondence (*diplomatische Korrespondenz*), marriage correspondence (*Heiratskorrespondenz*), letters of queens and princes (*Briefe von Königinnen und Prinzen*), correspondence of dignitaries (*Korrespondenz der Würdenträger*), letters to and from vassals (*Briefe an und von Vasallen*), miscellaneous letters (*verschiedene Briefe*), and oracle letters (*Orakelbriefe*).

Although primarily functional documents, letters could employ elaborate salutations, petitions, accusations, negotiations, quoted speech, narrative retrospection, and political self-presentation. They could also be excerpted or reproduced within historiographical compositions, as in the account of the Egyptian queen's request for a Hittite prince in the Deeds of Šuppiluliuma. The epistolary corpus therefore occupies an intermediate position between administrative communication, diplomacy,

and literary narrative [HPM].

12§. **Legal and normative literature** (*Rechts- und Instruktionsliteratur*) comprises laws (*Gesetze*), state treaties (*Staatsverträge*), edicts and decrees (*Erlasse und Dekrete*), royal ordinances (*Königserlasse*), instructions (*Instruktionen*), land-grant documents (*Landschenkungsurkunden*), court records (*Gerichtsprotokolle*), depositions (*Zeugenaussagen*), and indictments (*Anklageschriften*).

The treaties distinguish between parity treaties (*paritätische Staatsverträge*) and subordination treaties (*Subordinationsverträge*) and unite binding obligations with an oath, their characteristic components include a preamble, an historical introduction, stipulations, lists of divine witnesses, oath clauses, and blessings or curses. Instructions regulate the conduct of priests, palace personnel, military officers, provincial governors, bodyguards, and other officials, while the laws employ predominantly casuistic formulations. Because these texts frequently incorporate historiographical narration, moral exempla, rhetoric, and ideological argumentation, they cannot be reduced to purely technical legal documentation; for the legal corpus and its comparative context, see von Schuler [von Schuler 1987–1990], [Loginov and Shelestin 2019], and [HPM].

13§. **Divinatory and omen literature** (*Divinations- und Omenliteratur*) encompasses both transmitted omen series (*Omenserien*) and records of practical divination. The former include celestial omens (*Himmelsomina*), especially lunar, solar, stellar, and eclipse omens, terrestrial omens (*terrestrische Omina*), medical omens (*medizinische Omina*), birth omens (*Geburtsomina*), physiognomic omens (*physiognomische Omina*), animal omens (*Tieromina*), dream omens (*Traumomina*), and hemerologies (*Hemerologien*).

Practical texts comprise oracle inquiries (*Orakelanfragen*), oracle reports (*Orakelberichte*), extispicy (*Leberschau und Eingeweideschau*), lot oracles (*Losorakel*), bird oracles (*Vogelarakel*), snake oracles (*Schlangenorakel*), combined oracles (*kombinierte Orakel*), and oracle letters (*Orakelbriefe*).

These documents record questions concerning campaigns, royal conduct, cults, festivals, illness, and divine anger, together with the procedure, observed sign, interpretation, and frequently a sequence of confirmatory inquiries. They thus combine Mesopotamian scholarly traditions with specifically Hittite practices of political and cultic decision-making and belong primarily to technical scribal culture rather than literature in the narrow aesthetic sense [Haas 2008, HPM].

14§. **Scholarly and technical writing** (*gelehrtes und fachliches Schrifttum*) comprises the texts through which palace and temple scribes preserved, classified, translated, taught, and applied specialized knowledge. Its scholarly component includes lexical lists (*lexikalische Listen*), sign lists (*Zeichenlisten*), bilingual and trilingual vocabularies or exercises (*zwei- und dreisprachige Vokabulare bzw. Übungen*), and translation literature (*Übersetzungsliteratur*), encompassing adapted Mesopotamian

hymns, epics like Gilgameš, wisdom compositions, and other learned works in Sumerian, Akkadian, Hurrian, and Hittite. The organization and transmission of this knowledge are documented by tablet catalogues (*Tafelkataloge*), library labels (*Bibliotheksetiketten*), colophons (*Kolophone*), series designations, scribal notes, and school copies, which record textual incipits, tablet sequence, authorship or scribal responsibility, provenance, completeness, and conditions of copying. Closely related list-based forms include god lists (*Götterlisten*), offering lists (*Opferlisten*), plant and seed lists (*Pflanzen- und Samenlisten*), eponym lists (*Eponymenlisten*), and other classificatory compilations.

Its technical component comprises hippological literature (*hippologisches Schrifttum*), especially the multilingual horse-training manuals (*Pferdetrainingsanleitungen*) associated with Kikkuli, also known for its Indo-Aryan superstrate lexical components, medical and therapeutic texts (*medizinische und therapeutische Texte*), including diagnostic descriptions, remedies for fever and eye diseases, pharmacological recipes, and treatments combining materia medica with incantation, and chemical and glass-making recipes (*chemische und Glasrezepte*), which preserve procedural knowledge concerning the preparation and transformation of materials. Instructions concerning administration, agriculture, cult management, construction, and specialized crafts may likewise display the sequential and formulaic structure of technical manuals, although their classification remains uncertain. These compositions are therefore better understood not as literature in the narrow aesthetic sense, but as a multilingual scribal knowledge tradition (*gelehrte Schrift- und Wissenstradition*) in which classification, translation, textual transmission, practical instruction, and ritual expertise formed an integrated intellectual culture maintained by the learned scribes of the palace and temples [Haas 2006, HPM].

15§. As a brief **conclusion**. Research on Hittite literature continues to advance. Recent discoveries at Kayalıpınar, probably ancient Šamuḫa, and renewed excavations at Ḫattuša demonstrate that the textual corpus is far from exhausted and may still yield significant new material. At the same time, expanding digital resources are improving access to the sources and integrating previously scattered scholarship. The growing number of comparative studies and the continuing development of corpora for the lesser-attested Anatolian languages further broaden the prospects for understanding Hittite literature within its wider Anatolian and Ancient Near Eastern context.

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- Electronic Text Corpus of Sumerian Literature (**ETCSL**) <https://etcsl.orinst.ox.ac.uk>
- Hethitologie Portal Mainz (**HPM**) <https://hethport.net/HPM/index.php>